

02

VOCABULARY

Vocabulary comprises one of the most scoring bunch of questions in CDS exam. A sound vocabulary is always anticipated to crack the questions based on synonyms and antonyms. The following chapter gives you an edge in mastering the words that have importance in the examination.



Vocabulary is a broad concept in itself. One can enhance one's language skills by acquiring a good hold over **vocabulary**. To score high in the CDS exam (English Paper), a candidate should improve his/her vocabulary skills. It helps one in solving questions of Comprehension, Cloze Test, Antonyms and Synonyms etc.

Here, we illustrate some steps to enrich vocabulary.

- Step I Identify the Word** Whenever we come across a new word in a sentence while reading a textbook, newspaper or a magazine, we should look up its meaning. This is the best way to enhance one's vocabulary. Suppose you come across a word 'Antique' and you don't know its meaning, you consult a dictionary and find its meaning which is 'old and often valuable'.
- Step II Identify the Antonyms of that Word** Along with the meaning of a word, its antonyms (words with opposite meaning) should also be taken into consideration. A good knowledge of words and their antonyms is very beneficial from the examination point of view. e.g. Opposite of Antique is modern.
- Step III Identify the Synonyms of that Word** The knowledge of words that are similar or closer in meaning to a word is very useful. It makes a student efficient enough to have a strong sense of the language. Example: 'Antique' can be replaced by Traditional or Ancient.
- Step IV Form a Proper Sentence** This is one of the most important parts in vocabulary building. It serves to stimulate memory by recalling the words as and when needed, apart from making the proper sense and the use of words clear. e.g. To be more familiar with a word, we should use it in sentence form. For 'Antique' a proper sentence is 'People love to purchase antique items.'

A

Aback Taken by surprise

Synonyms Surprised, thrown off guard

Antonyms Relax, Contended

- *Everyone was taken aback by Sachin's decision to quit.*

Abandon To leave something and never return to it

Synonyms Desert, Leave

Antonyms Continue, Carry on

- *Railways has abandoned their outer signal.*

Abase To humiliate

Synonyms Degrade, Disregard, Dishonour

Antonyms Regard, Honour, Respect

- *Abasing someone is immoral.*

Abashed Make someone feel embarrassed or ashamed

Synonyms Embarrass, Humiliate

Antonyms Unabashed, Undaunted

- *He is abashed of his own mistakes.*

Abate To make or become less strong

Synonyms Weaken, Lessen

Antonyms Strengthen, Intensify

- *We waited for the wind to abate.*

Abbreviate To shorten

Synonyms To abridge, To curtail

Antonyms Lengthen, Enhance

- *The voluminous book was abbreviated for the convenience of the students.*

Abdicate To give up power

Synonyms Relinquish, Renounce

Antonyms Accept

- *The old king abdicated the throne.*

Aberrant straying from the right or normal way

Synonyms Deviant, atypical

Antonyms Normal, Usual

- *Aberrant behaviour can be a sign of rabies in an animal.*

Abet To encourage someone to do wrong

Synonyms Assist, Incite, Encourage

Antonyms Demotivate, Prevent

- *She abetted the thief in the robbery.*

Abeyance A state of not happening or being used at present

Synonyms Abandon, Suspension, Discontinuation

Antonyms Continuation, Resumption

- *The old generator has been in abeyance for six months.*

Abhor To feel hatred or dislike

Synonyms Detest, Loathe

Antonyms Like, Admire

- *The world would be like heaven if all the people abhor none.*

Abide To accept something in accordance with

Synonyms Obey, follow

Antonyms Flout, Reject

- *Citizens have to abide by the rules.*

Abnegate To give-up; renunciation

Synonyms Discard, Reject

Antonym Accept

- *Abnegating superstitions is advantageous.*

Abound To exist in large numbers or amounts

Synonyms Plenty, Suffice

Antonyms Scarce, Scanty

- *Kiwis abound in New Zealand.*

Abrasive Showing little concern for feeling of others

Synonyms Rude, Annoying, Unfriendly

Antonyms Pleasant, Friendly

- *Abrasive behaviour of employees may prove harmful to a firm.*

Abrogate To end a law, agreement or custom formally

Synonyms Abandon, Abort

Antonyms Institute, Introduce

- *Our country should abrogate outdated laws.*

Abstain Withhold or Refrain

Synonyms Avoid, Cease

Antonyms Do, Continue

- *It is worth while to abstain from intoxicants.*

Abstruse Difficult to understand, obscure.

Synonyms Esoteric, Perplexing

Antonyms Clear, Obvious

- *You are not the only one who finds Einstein's theory abstruse.*

Absurd Ridiculous, Unreasonable

Synonyms Foolish, Ridiculous

Antonyms Reasonable, Genuine

- *Political parties indulge in absurd arguments before the election.*

Abut To border upon

Synonyms Adjoin, Lie next to, Adjacent

Antonyms Far, Opposite

- *Our land abuts a nature preserve.*

Abysmal extremely poor or bad

Synonyms Awful, Terrible

Antonyms Good, Pleasant

- *The quality of her work is abysmal.*

Accede To agree

Synonyms Consent, Acceptance

Antonyms Disagree, Refusal, Denial

- *The business contract between the two parties was acceded successfully.*

Accentuate To emphasise or to make noticeable

Synonyms Highlight, Hype

Antonyms Shadowed, Downtrodden

- *People often shout to accentuate their opinion.*

Accessible Easy to obtain, approachable

Synonyms Achievable, Acquiresome

Antonyms Remote, Distant

- *Everything is accessible with the Internet.*

Accessory A thing which can be added to something else in order to make it more useful, versatile or attractive

Synonyms Adornment, Retrofit

Antonym Subsidiary

- *Cellular phones are incomplete without the accessories.*

Acclaim Public approval and praise

Synonyms Praise, Applaud, Cheer

Antonyms Criticise

- *Sardar Patel was an acclaimed leader.*

Accolade An award or an expression of praise.

Synonyms Appreciation, Honour, Award

Antonym Criticism

- *Getting success is a great accolade.*

Accord Be harmonious or consistent

Synonyms Concord, Agreement

Antonyms Disagree, Contrast

- *The board of directors could not reach an accord in the annual meeting.*

Accost Approach and address angrily or aggressively

Synonyms Annoy, Confront

Antonyms Aid, Help

- *On the mistake of the son, father accosted him.*

Accrue To increase in number or amount

Synonyms To collect, To accumulate

Antonyms Disperse, Dwindle

- *Crossing for a single run accrued the score of the team.*

Adept Skilful

Synonyms Expert, Efficient

Antonyms Unskilled, Inapt

- *It seems that he is adept in computers.*

Adjourn Temporary breaking-off

Synonyms Suspend, Interrupt

Antonyms Carry out, Advance

- *He has adjourned his journey.*
- *The court is adjourned for the day.*

Adjunct Something joined or added to another thing but is not an essential part of it

Synonyms Supplement, Addition

Antonyms Subtraction, Lessening

- *The witness of the case has adjuncted a new twist in it.*

Adjure To urge solemnly

Synonym Request

Antonym Answer

- *On the continuous adjuring of students, a picnic was arranged.*

Admonish To warn

Synonyms Scold, Reprove

Antonyms Allow, Compliment

- *The teacher admonished the student for his insolent behaviour.*

Adorn Make more beautiful or attractive

Synonyms To embellish, To decorate

Antonyms Malign, Deface

- *The temple is adorned with flowers.*

Adroit Very skilful

Synonyms Expert, Proficient

Antonyms Unskilled, Incompetent

- *The showroom needs an adroit mechanic.*

Afflict Affect adversely

Synonyms Suffer, Bother

Antonyms Comfort, Aid

- *The flood has greatly afflicted the crops in this village.*

Affluence Having a lot of money

Synonyms Wealth, Prosperity

Antonyms Scarcity, Poverty

- *Generally, affluent fathers have spoiled kids.*

Affront An action or remark that causes outrage or offence

Synonyms Insult, Offence

Antonyms Honour, Compliment

- *Poor dressing sense often causes affront.*

Aggrandize Increase power, status or wealth of

Synonyms Exalt, Boost

Antonyms Abase, Degrade

- *Its a movie that aggrandizes the bad guys.*

Aggravate To make a problem worse

Synonyms Worsen, Compound

Antonyms Soothe, Calm

- *The symptoms were aggravated by drinking alcohol.*

Agog very eager or curious to hear or see something

Synonyms Eager, Impatient

Antonyms Reluctant, Uninterested

- *He was all agog on hearing the news of his promotion.*

Altercation A noisy argument or disagreement, especially in public

Synonyms Quarrel, Bickering

Antonyms Agreement, Harmony

- *A general political talk should not lead to an altercation.*

Altruism Disinterested and selfless concern for the well-being of others.

Synonyms Benevolence, Humanitarianism

Antonyms Greediness, Meanness

- *Mother Teresa is known for her altruism.*

Amalgamate To combine to form a larger group

Synonyms To merge, Combine

Antonyms Separate, Disjoin

- *Hutchison and Essar group amalgamated to form Hutchison-Essar.*

Ambiguous Open to more than one interpretation, not having one obvious meaning

Synonyms Unclear, Confusing

Antonyms Clear, Obvious

- *Ambiguous answers must be removed.*

Ameliorate Making a situation better, less painful

Synonyms Mitigate, Improve

Antonyms Worsen, Aggravate

- *Government grant is ameliorating the situation in the territory.*

Amenable Open and responsive to suggestions

Synonyms Compliant, Manageable, Persuadable

Antonyms Stubborn, Rigid, Non-compliant

- *A better way to resolve the problems is being amenable.*

Amicable Friendly behaviour of a person

Synonyms Friendly, Good-natured

Antonyms Unfriendly, Hostile

- *Noble people are always amicable.*

Annul To make something legally void

Synonyms Cancel, Abolish, Invalidate

Antonyms Accept, Validate

- *The contract was annulled by the second party.*

Anomaly Deviation from the standard

Synonyms Oddity, Peculiarity

Antonyms Conformity, Normality

- *We do not publish cheap quality books as it is an anomaly to our policy.*

Antagonism A strong feeling of dislike or hatred

Synonyms Hate, Prejudice

Antonyms Love, Affection

- *Man cannot be an antagonist as he has to live in the society.*

Antipathy A strong feeling of dislike

Synonyms Aversion, Dislike

Antonyms Affinity, Cordiality

- *Pakistan's antipathy is open to India.*

Antithesis The direct or exact opposite

Synonyms Counterpart, Converse

Antonym Same

- *It seems that he has decided to be in antithesis of my opinion.*

Aphorism A short, wise and true statement

Synonyms Adage, Maxim

Antonyms Nonsense, Absurdity

- *"Honesty is the best policy" is a very practical aphorism.*

Aplomb Confidence and style

Synonyms Assurance, Poise

Antonyms Gaucheness, Discomposure

- *Continuous failure had a great effect on his aplomb.*

Apocryphal Well-known but probably not true

Synonyms Fictitious, Made-up

Antonyms Authentic, Real

- *Existence of God is an apocryphal fact to the people world wide.*

Apogee Most successful part of something

Synonyms The top, Apex

Antonyms Bottom, Base

- *Romance is the apogee of a relationship.*

Appease to make someone pleased or less angry by giving or saying something they desire

Synonyms To pacify, Placate

Antonyms Annoy, Irritate

- *His appeasing behaviour is always appreciated.*

Append To add something to the end of a writing

Synonyms Add, Attach

Antonyms Disjoin, Detach

- *It is always advisable to append the hints to a mathematical problem.*

Apportion To divide something among people

Synonyms Distribute, Allocate

Antonyms Keep, Withhold

- *The property of the deceased man was apportioned between his two sons.*

B

Babble To talk or say something in a quick, confused, excited or silly way

Synonyms Chatter, Bumble

Antonyms Quiet, Sense

- *He seems to be babbling.*

Badger To try to make someone do something by asking them many times

Synonyms Pester, Bother, Torment

Antonyms Aid, Delight

- *The peon had to be badgered to get the form signed by the principal.*

Baleful Full of evil intentions, menacing

Synonyms Destructive, Malignant

Antonyms Good, Helping, Promising

- *His baleful behaviour was strange.*

Banal Trite; something boring ; ordinary and not original

Synonyms Common place, Trite, Boring, Dull

Antonyms Entertaining, Original

- *I hate the places that seem banal.*

Bane A cause of great distress or annoyance.

Synonyms Ruin, Destruction

Antonyms Blessing, Boon, Advantage

- *Traffic congestion and air pollution are major banes for Delhi and Delhiites.*

Bashful Tending to feel uncomfortable with other people and be embarrassed easily; shy

Synonyms Diffident, Modest, Meek, Coy, Nervous

Antonyms Open, Confident

- *She feels bashful in my company.*

Berate To criticize or scold severely

Synonyms Lash out, Tear into, Abuse

Antonyms Praise, Compliment

- *Father berated his son for his mistakes.*

Bereavement The situation you are in when a close friend or a family member has just died

Synonyms Death, Loss

Antonym Happiness

- *Bereavement caused by my father's death is immeasurable.*

Bestow To give or confer honour to someone

Synonyms Award, Give, Grant, Present

Antonyms Deprive, Refuse, Take

- *A lot of awards are bestowed upon him.*

Bigotry Intolerance towards those who hold different opinion from oneself

Synonyms Fanaticism, Prejudice

Antonyms Tolerance, Impartiality

- *A deeply ingrained bigotry prevented her from even considering the arguments.*

Bizarre Strange and difficult to explain

Synonyms Strange, Weird

Antonyms Explainable, Normal

- *The bizarre events taking place in the deserted house led the people to assume that it was haunted.*

Blabber Talk foolishly

Synonyms Chatter, Babble

Antonym Sense

- *Blabbering is what one can expect from fools.*

Bohemian A socially unconventional person, especially an artist or a writer

Synonym Non-conformist

Antonym Conformist

- *The Bohemian attitude is considered rebellious.*

Bolster To support or strengthen

Synonyms Strengthen, Reinforce

Antonyms Discourage, Undermine

- *More money is needed to bolster the industry.*

Boor A person who is rude and does not consider other people's feelings

Synonyms Lout, Rogue

Antonyms Civilised, Decent, Modest

- *Terrorists are nothing but boors.*



Bovine Relating to or affecting cattle, looking or acting like a cow
 Synonyms Cow-like, Cattle-like
 • *She stared at us with a stupid bovine expression.*

Brag To speak proudly of what you have done or what you own.
 Synonyms Swagger, Boast
 Antonym Be modest
 • *He was bragging about his success.*

Brash Showing too much confidence and too little respect
 Synonyms Arrogant, Brazen
 Antonyms Diffident, Meek
 • *A brash man has less friends.*

Bumble To speak or move in a confused way
 Synonyms Lurch, Stumble
 Antonyms Efficient, Expert
 • *Bumbling persons create a doubt to security.*

Bungle To do something badly or unsuccessfully
 Synonyms Mishandle, Mismanage
 Antonym Succeed
 • *He has bungled the whole work.*

Buoyant Happy and confident
 Synonyms Happy, Joyous
 Antonyms Unhappy, Sad
 • *He was very buoyant about the visit to Agra.*

Burgeon To grow or develop quickly
 Synonyms Expand, Swell
 Antonyms Shrink, Contract
 • *Terrorism is burgeoning across the border.*

Burly A large and strong person
 Synonyms Tawny, Gigantic
 Antonyms Lean, Thin
 • *There must be a burly man for the role of a demon.*

Bustling If a place is bustling, it is full of busy activity
 Synonyms Dashing, Scurrying
 Antonyms Quiet, Inactive, Dormant
 • *The house, usually bustling with activity, was strangely silent.*

Cabal A group of people who secretly work together
 Synonyms Clique, Faction
 Antonym Individual
 • *He was assassinated by a cabal of aides.*

Cache A hidden store of provision, weapons, treasure; to hide weapons or other things
 Synonyms Hoard, Store
 Antonyms Discard, Remove
 • *People must create a cache of medicines for emergency.*

Cajole To persuade someone to do something by coaxing or flattery
 Synonyms Persuade, Coax
 Antonyms Dissuade, Discourage
 • *He knows how to cajole people into doing what he wants.*

Calamity An event that brings terrible loss, lasting distress or severe affliction
 Synonyms Tragedy, Catastrophe
 Antonyms Blessing, Godsend
 • *The great calamity was brought to rest.*

Callous Showing or having an insensitive and cruel disregard for others.
 Synonyms Insensitive; Unsympathetic
 Antonyms Sensitive, Sympathetic
 • *People often think that doctors are callous.*

Calumny A false accusation
 Synonyms Defamation, Slander
 Antonyms Eulogy, Praise
 • *He is a victim of calumny.*

Camouflage To disguise
 Synonyms Hide, Conceal
 Antonyms Reveal, Show
 • *The camouflaged players arrived at the airport.*

Canard A false, report or story
 Synonyms Tale, Story
 Antonym Truth
 • *The newspaper was sued for publishing a canard about a celebrity.*

Canny Very clever and able to make intelligent decisions.
 Synonyms Clever, Shrewd
 Antonyms Uncanny, Daft
 • *Rohan is a canny card player.*

Cantankerous Bad tempered, argumentative and uncooperative
 Synonyms Bad tempered, Uncooperative
 Antonyms Affable, Good-natured
 • *Children are by nature cantankerous.*

Capacious Having a lot of space
 Synonyms Spacious, Open
 Antonyms Small, Cramped
 • *A bungalow is a capacious house to live-in.*

Cardinal Of the greatest importance, fundamental.
 Synonyms Significant, Fundamental
 Antonym Unimportant
 • *Cardinal facts of the case are hidden.*

Careen To go forward quickly while moving from side to side
 Synonyms Lurch, Rock
 Antonyms Crawl, Creep
 • *I saw the duck careening through the ponds.*

Castigate To criticise severely
 Synonyms Rebuke, Chide, Scold
 Antonyms Admire, Praise
 • *Odd behaviour of a person is a matter of castigation.*

Catalyst Stimulus; a person who causes change by his presence
 Synonyms Impetus, Incentive
 Antonyms Inhibitor, Preventer
 • *Birbal was a catalyst in the court of Akbar.*

Catapult To suddenly put someone into an important position; to propel
 Synonyms Excel, Marshal
 Antonyms To recede, Decline
 • *Someone cannot be catapulted to be the chief straight way.*

Charismatic Possessing spiritual grace; inspiring
 Synonyms Charming, Fascinating
 Antonyms Offensive, Frightening
 • *Modi is a charismatic leader.*